Benjamin Foster | professional website

I. Professional Introduction & Teaching Philosophy

The Journey from Enforcer to Facilitator

My residency at Multicultural Academy Charter School (MACS) represents a pivotal shift in my professional identity. Having served as a building substitute for over a year, my initial relationship with the student body was defined by monitoring and rule enforcement. My student teaching experience has been a deliberate journey in transforming that perception.

My Philosophy: I believe that effective English Language Arts instruction must be grounded in **Domain 1b (Knowing and Valuing Students)**. By meeting students at their diverse competency levels—ranging from 4th-grade to 12th-grade reading levels—I strive to create a "culture for learning" that is collaborative rather than combative. I advocate for a "soft start" approach, using rapport-building and personal check-ins to invite students into complex literary worlds, from the fractured moral landscapes of Jesmyn Ward's *Salvage the Bones* to the timeless archetypes of Greek Mythology.

II. Framework for Teaching: The Four Domains

Domain 1: Planning and Preparation

Focus: Scaffolding and Moral Landscapes

- **Evidence of Proficiency:** Developed a two-lesson sequence for *Salvage the Bones* focusing on "Character Transgression."
- **Key Strategies:** Utilized **Graphic Organizers** to help students map the "moral landscape" of Bois Sauvage.

Artifact 1: Drexel Lesson Plan

Drexel Lesson Plan Template

Teacher: Benjamin Foster

Grade: 11th Grade

Content Area: English Language Arts

Content and Standards:

- **CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.RL.11-12.1:** Cite strong and thorough textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly as well as inferences drawn from the text.
- **CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.RL.11-12.3:** Analyze the impact of the author's choices regarding how to develop and relate elements of a story or drama.

Prerequisites:

Students should have a basic understanding of the plot of *Salvage the Bones* (Chapters 1–5) and familiarity with the concept of Southern Gothic "grotesque" characters.

Essential Questions:

- How does a community's environment (poverty, survival, crisis) shape its definition of "right" and "wrong"?
- How does Jesmyn Ward use setting to establish a "moral landscape"?

Materials and Equipment:

- *Salvage the Bones* by Jesmyn Ward (Class set).
- "Morality in Salvage the Bones" Analysis Worksheet.
- Promethean Board (for modeling the "Pit" imagery analysis).
- Mirriam-Webster online (for vocabulary support).

Instructional Objective:

Following a class discussion on communal values and a close reading of pages 108–114, students will complete a morality analysis worksheet that correctly identifies three specific moral codes in the text supported by direct quotes and 2–3 sentences of analysis.

Instructional Procedures:

- **Before:** * **Anticipatory Set:** "Do Now" (5 min): What do you think defines "right" and "wrong" behavior in a community? How do those ideas change during a crisis?
    - **Mini-lesson:** Teacher models "The Pit" analysis on the Promethean board, explaining how hellish imagery establishes a fractured moral landscape.
- **During:** * **Independent Reading:** Students read pages 108–114 (focusing on the interaction between Junior and Daddy).
    - **Independent Practice:** Students work on Part 2 of the Morality Worksheet, identifying where characters' actions align or clash with traditional morality. Teacher circulates to provide one-on-one "desk-side" coaching.
- **After:** * **Closure/Assessment:** Exit Ticket: "Explain one way the morality in Bois Sauvage differs from your own moral code."

Assessment:

The primary assessment is the "Morality in Salvage the Bones" worksheet. Success is measured by the student's ability to provide a direct quote and explain its connection to the community's moral code in 2–3 sentences.

Differentiated Instruction:

- **Process:** For students reading at the elementary/middle school level, the teacher provides a "Master Guide" for the film/text and utilizes pre-taught vocabulary (e.g., *transgression, grotesque*).
- **Product:** Students with IEPs may choose to discuss their responses verbally with the teacher before writing to ensure comprehension.
- **Environment:** Use of "proximity" (sitting near students like AR or BN) to encourage focus and engagement.

Artifact 2: Character Transgression Graphic Organizer

Character Transgression & The Moral Landscape

Focus: In Southern Gothic fiction, characters are defined by how they navigate a "fractured" moral world.

Character Name	**The Transgression (Action/Choice)**	**The Moral Code Broken**	**Textual Evidence (Quote/Page)**	**Analysis: What does this reveal?**
Skeetah	Stealing "cow wormer" for China.	Human life/property is more sacred than animal life.	"Skeetah puts his hands in his pockets... the cow wormer" (81).	Skeetah's survival hinges on loyalty to his dog over the laws of the human community.
Daddy	Excessive drinking/neglect of children.	A father's duty to nurture and protect his children.	"I'm surprised that Daddy doesn't have that sweet bread scent..." (62).	Parental roles are inverted; the children must "parent" themselves while Daddy retreats into addiction.

Esch	Navigating teen pregnancy in isolation.	Traditional expectations of adolescent behavior/sexual purity.	"Mama died, and there was no one left for me to hold on to" (58).	Esch's "transgression" is a response to the vacuum of maternal care and the decay of the family property.

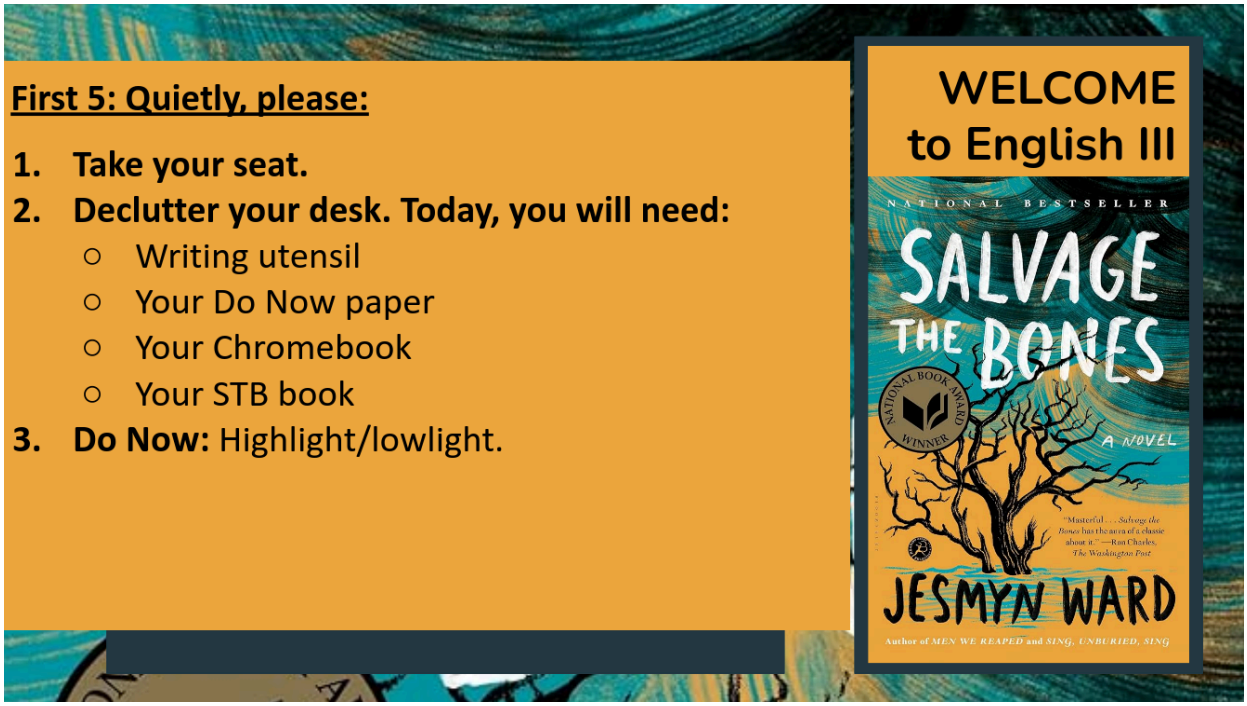
Reflection:

These artifacts demonstrate my ability to meet students at their competency level (Domain 1b) while pushing them toward high-level character analysis. By using a graphic organizer to track 'transgressions,' I helped students bridge the gap between plot-level understanding and the complex themes of Southern Gothic literature. This structure allowed for both independent thinking and scaffolded support for my diverse learners at MACS.

Domain 2: The Classroom Environment

Focus: Cultivating Respect and Managing Transitions

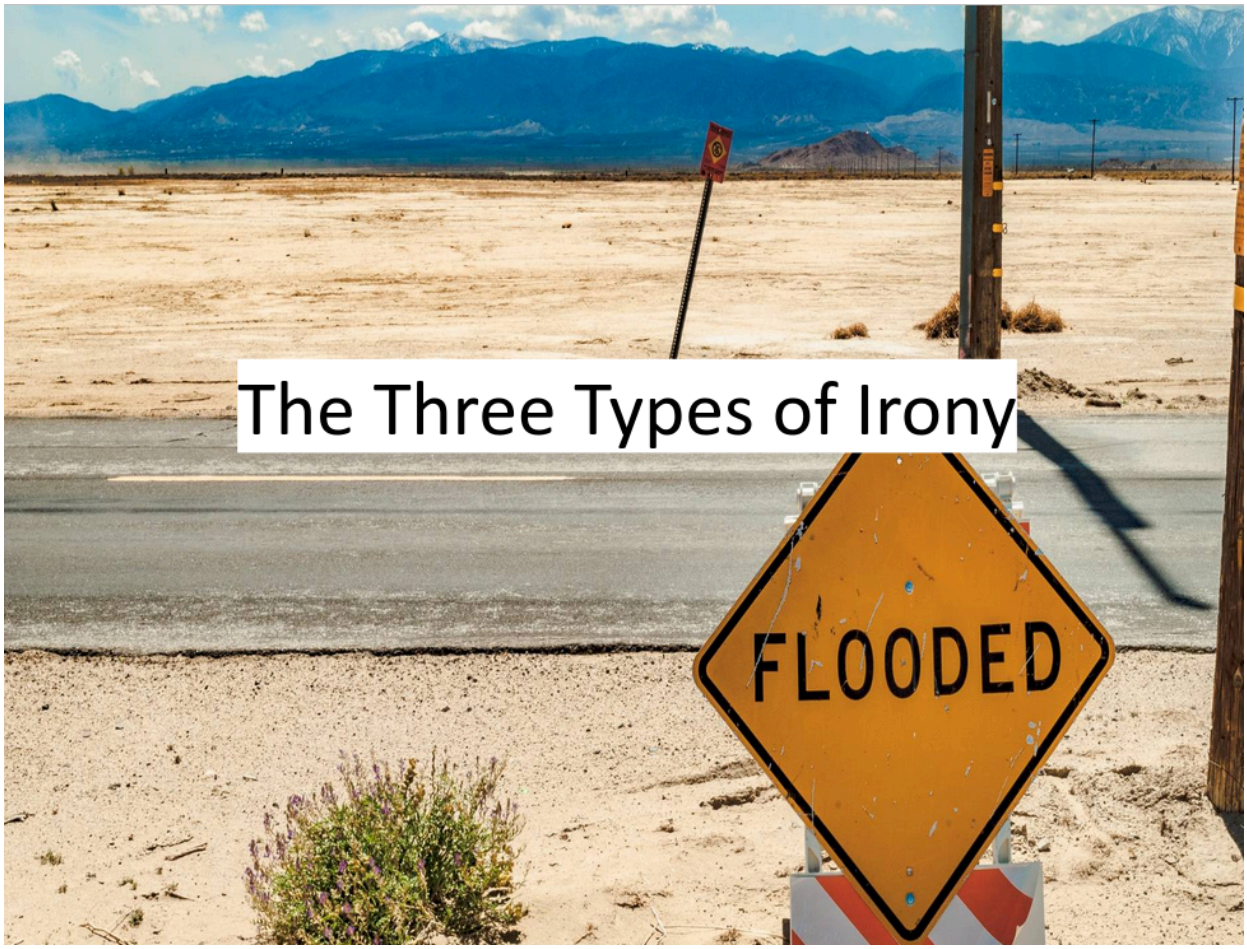
- **Evidence of Proficiency:** Shifted from "no-nonsense enforcement" to proactive rapport building.
- **Key Strategies: The Threshold Greeting:** Greeting every student by name at the door to set a positive tone.
    - **Atmospheric Management:** Using piano music to calm the environment during independent work.
    - **Non-Escalatory Redirection:** Using proximity and "the pause" to regain attention rather than public confrontation.



Domain 3: Instruction

Focus: Engaging Students in Critical Discourse

- **Evidence of Proficiency:** Moving students from basic comprehension to high-level analysis.
- **Key Strategies:** * **Modeling:** Physically typing/writing on the Promethean board to show students *how* to annotate or build a thesis.
    - **Participation Techniques:** Implementing "Raised Hands" to manage "chorusing" and ensure diverse voices (e.g., engaging quiet students like CC or CC).
    - **Real-World Connections:** Discussing Pennsylvania vs. New York polities to ground abstract concepts.


The Three Types of Irony
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What is Irony?

- Irony is when there is a **contrast** between **what is expected** and **what actually happens**.
- Authors use irony to add meaning, tension, or deeper understanding to a story.
- There are three main types: **verbal**, **situational**, and **dramatic irony**.

The Three Types of Irony

- **Verbal Irony**: What is said is different from what is meant.
- **Situational Irony**: What happens is the opposite of what is expected.
- **Dramatic Irony**: The audience knows something that the characters do not.

Verbal Irony – Example from *Fences* (1985)

- **Verbal irony** happens when a character says something but means the opposite.
- In *Fences*, Troy often talks about responsibility and honor, but **his actions contradict his words**.
- For example, he claims to care about his family, yet he betrays Rose by having an affair.
- This contrast between **what Troy says** and **what he does** shows verbal irony.

Situational Irony – *Of Mice and Men* (1937)

- **Situational irony** occurs when the outcome is different from what is expected.
- George and Lennie dream of owning their own farm and living a peaceful life.
- The **expectation** is that they will finally achieve their dream.
- Instead, Lennie accidentally kills Curley's wife and George must kill Lennie, **subverting the situational expectation**, and destroying their dream.

Dramatic Irony – *Just Mercy* (2014)

- **Dramatic irony** is when the audience knows something that the characters do not.
- In *Just Mercy*, the reader knows that Walter McMillian is innocent.
- However, many people in the justice system still believe he is guilty.
- This creates tension and frustration because we know the truth while others ignore it.

Why Do Authors Use Irony?

- To make stories more interesting and meaningful.
- To show deeper truths about characters and society.
- To create emotional impact and make readers think critically.

Conclusion

- Irony helps readers understand themes and characters more deeply.
- *Of Mice and Men* uses **situational irony** to show how randomness and violence stymie the efforts of people, resulting in failed dreams and death, in contrast to people's hope for peace and happiness.
- *Fences* uses **verbal irony** to reveal Troy's hypocrisy. As a figure symbolizing the American blue-collar family man, representing him as a hypocrite uncovers the foolishness of American social values.
- *Just Mercy* uses **dramatic irony** to compel the reader to empathize with his own helplessness in proving McMillian's innocence.

Domain 4: Professional Responsibilities

Focus: Reflective Practice and Collaboration

- **Evidence of Proficiency:** Consistent engagement in the "Reflective Cycle" with mentors Kenny, Martinson, and Sharon.
- **Key Growth Areas:**
  - **Economy of Language:** Learning to give clearer, more concise directions to prevent student confusion.
  - **Professional Growth:** Actively tracking student achievement and identifying "pain points" (e.g., recognizing when students haven't read and pivoting to in-class reading).

Benjamin Foster
March 20, 2026
EDUC-540-901
Study of Student Achievement
Teacher Candidate: Benjamin Foster
School: Multicultural Academy Charter School
Grade Level: 11th Grade

Content Area: English Language Arts
Focus
I am currently student teaching in the English department at Multicultural Academy Charter School in the Hunting Park neighborhood of North Philadelphia. The school is a public charter institution serving approximately 200–250 students. The student population is predominantly African American, and students are admitted through a citywide lottery system, resulting in a diverse range of learners across the city.
For this study, I focus on two 11th-grade English classes, each consisting of approximately 15–20 students. Based on classroom observations and assessment data, the majority of students are performing below grade level in English Language Arts. Many students demonstrate reading and writing abilities at the middle school level, with several performing at the elementary level. Additionally, a significant number of students have Individualized Education Programs (IEPs), requiring differentiation and scaffolded instruction.
Despite these academic challenges, classroom behavior is generally positive, and students consistently complete assigned work. However, informal assessments—including class discussions, exit tickets, and written responses—indicate that while students can identify literary elements, they struggle to engage in deeper analysis.
The current unit focuses on Salvage the Bones by Jesmyn Ward. Prior lessons on figurative language showed that approximately 75% of students could identify literary devices, but fewer than 40% could explain their significance. This gap highlights a need to strengthen analytical thinking.
The focus of this study is improving student achievement in character analysis, specifically understanding how characters interact with and transgress a complex moral landscape in Southern Gothic literature.
This aligns with Danielson's Framework for Teaching, Domain 3 (Instruction):● 3b: Questioning and Discussion
● 3c: Student Engagement
Instructional strategies include:
Graphic organizers
Structured discussion
Modeling
Scaffolded writing
Student learning is measured through exit tickets, written responses, and class participation.

III. Evidence of Student Learning

Analysis of Student Achievement

Goal	Strategy	Outcome

Character Analysis	Graphic organizers on "transgression"	Students identified how Southern Gothic characters navigate fractured moral worlds.
Engagement	Highlight/Lowlight & Shout Outs	Increased participation from students who previously remained disengaged or "heads down."
Literary Theory	Greek Myth Contextualization	Built foundational knowledge for the study of *Medea*.

IV. Reflection & Next Steps

Looking forward, my goal is to continue "tightening" my pacing and "timestamping" activities to maintain momentum. I am committed to the MACS community and the belief that even the most "problematic" student deserves a positive interaction every single day.